

SOURCES OF ANCIENT INDIAN HISTORY

Trace -> context -> chronology -> corroboration -> qualified reconstruction

Core evidence rail | Archaeology | Epigraphy | Numismatics | Texts | Foreign accounts | Science | Answer method

Read each panel as: definition -> named evidence -> inference -> limitation.

PANEL 1/14 — FROM TRACE TO DEFENSIBLE HISTORY

SURVIVING TRACE

- identity/authenticity
- provenance or archaeological provenience
- date and transmission
- author/audience/purpose/genre
- comparison and corroboration
- silence and alternatives
- QUALIFIED HISTORICAL CLAIM

RULE: texts are not transparent facts; archaeology is not self-interpreting.

PANEL 2/14 — SOURCE UNIVERSE

ARCHAEOLOGY settlement, technology, foodways | context/sampling
EPIGRAPHY acts, rulers, donors, institutions | formula/elite survival
NUMISMATICS authority, metrology, circulation | hoard/movement bias
LITERATURE norm, memory, ideas, vocabulary | genre/redaction
FOREIGN routes, comparison, synchronism | standpoint/translation
VISUAL/ORAL patronage, iconography, memory | convention/performance
SCIENCE ranges, diet, mobility, environment | sample/baseline limits
NO FIXED HIERARCHY: fit the source to the question.

PANEL 3/14 — ORIGIN AND CHRONOLOGY RAIL

PREHISTORY archaeology dominates
HARAPPAN PROTOHISTORY c. 2600–1900 BCE; script undeciphered
VEDIC/POST-VEDIC layered oral-textual traditions + archaeology
EARLY HISTORIC readable inscriptions, coins, cities, many texts
3rd c. BCE Ashokan corpus gives firm epigraphic anchors
1837 Prinsep's decisive Brahmi decipherment step
MODERN METHOD archaeometry, bioarchaeology, digital corpora

PANEL 4/14 — ARCHAEOLOGICAL METHOD

SURVEY → SITE → EXCAVATION → STRATIGRAPHY → ASSEMBLAGE → INTERPRETATION
vertical trench = sequence | horizontal exposure = selected phase layout
lower undisturbed layer generally earlier

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vertical trench = sequence | horizontal exposure = selected phase layout
lower undisturbed layer generally earlier
BUT pits, intrusion, erosion and redeposition can disturb sequence
artefact → industry → assemblage → archaeological culture
CAUTION: archaeological culture ≠ race/language/tribe/dynasty/state

PANEL 5/14 — DATING AND SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

RELATIVE: stratigraphy | typology | seriation | cross-dating | palaeography
CHRONOMETRIC:
• radiocarbon → calibrated range for organic death
• TL → last suitable heating
• OSL → last sufficient light exposure
• isotopes → diet/mobility with baselines
• aDNA → ancestry/relatedness with sample limits
RULE: result dates a sample and association, not automatically a civilisation.

PANEL 6/14 — INSCRIPTIONS AND DECIPHERMENT

EPIGRAPHY = inscriptions | PALAEOGRAPHY = old writing/scripts
Brahmi: normally left to right; parent of many later scripts
Kharoshthi: right to left; north-west/Gandhara
Ashokan corpus: mainly Prakrit-Brahmi; north-west also Kharoshthi,
Greek and Aramaic settings
1837 Prinsep: cumulative comparative decipherment, not solitary intuition
GENRES:
edict → policy claim, not automatic implementation
prashasti → genealogy/ideology, but eulogy and omission
land grant → legal-fiscal act, not uniform enforcement
donation → donor/institution, but selection and survival bias

PANEL 7/14 — COINS AND NUMISMATICS

COIN = metal + weight + manufacture + legend + icon + die + wear + context
YIELD: issuer, title, relative sequence, standard, technology, circulation
HOARD: selected deposit; latest issue supplies a post-issue boundary
OVERSTRIKE: undertype earlier than or contemporary with overtype
Jogalthembi: Nahapana undertypes counter-struck by Gautamiputra Satakarni
LIMITS: distribution ≠ sovereignty; abundance ≠ total prosperity;
debasement can reflect scarcity, demand or policy, not only collapse.



PANEL 8/14 — LITERARY SOURCE FAMILIES

VEDIC	ritual, kinship, economy vocabulary oral layers
EPIC/PURANA	memory, values, genealogy recension/interpolation
BUDDHIST/JAINA	monastery, merchant, town, doctrine sectarian/didactic frame
SANGAM	chiefs, war, love, work, exchange bardic/dating issues
DHARMASHASTRA	norm, property, family, gender prescription ≠ practice
ARTHASHASTRA	statecraft model not one-reign transcript
COURT/BIOGRAPHY	patronage, ideology, political memory praise/aesthetic convention

TEXTUAL TIME:

composition → performance → addition/redaction → recension

→ surviving manuscript → critical edition/translation → interpretation

PANEL 9/14 — FOREIGN, VISUAL, ORAL AND LINGUISTIC EVIDENCE

FOREIGN ACCOUNT:

route + duration + purpose + language + informants + audience

- direct observation/hearsay + translation/survival

Megasthenes | Periplus | Faxian | Xuanzang | Arab-Persian witnesses

VISUAL/MATERIAL:

architecture, sculpture, painting, pottery, seals → patronage, technology, ritual and representation; image ≠ photograph; style ≠ exact date.

LINGUISTIC/ORAL:

loanwords, place names, genealogy, performed memory

language ≠ race/ancestry/polity; performance reshapes memory.

PANEL 10/14 — TRIANGULATION

MATCH chronology → geography → scale → independence → source purpose

TEXT CLAIM + INSCRIPTION/COIN + ARCHAEOLOGICAL CONTEXT + SCIENTIFIC RANGE

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CONVERGENCE / CONFLICT / RESIDUAL SILENCE

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BOUNDED HISTORICAL INFERENCE

Pali money terms + punch-marked coins → monetisation, regionally uneven

Sangam ports + Tamil-Brahmi + imported wares → connectivity, not total volume

Ashokan edicts + Pataliputra + classical testimony → complementary Mauryan views

PANEL 11/14 — ARCHIVE BIAS, FORGERY AND PRESERVATION

OVER-REPRESENTED: rulers, donors, literate elites, stone, metal, monuments

UNDER-REPRESENTED: labour, women, perishable life, oral communities

SILENCE TEST: expected production? survival? recognition? adequate search?

UNPROVENANCED OBJECT: material/style may survive; contextual history is lost

FORGERY CONTROL: material, script, custody, comparison and publication

INSTITUTIONS: ASI, museums and archives preserve evidence; catalogues and digital records remain revisable source layers.

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PANEL 12/14 — WHAT SOURCES REVEAL

POLITY edicts, prashastis, grants, coins, court texts
ECONOMY settlements, workshops, coins, ports, merchant/donor records
SOCIETY houses, burials, normative texts, donations, literature
RELIGION ritual texts, monasteries, icons, donations, architecture
GENDER prescriptions + female donations + household/material evidence
ENVIRONMENT pollen, seeds, fauna, soils, isotopes, palaeochannels
RULE: one source answers one dimension; cross-reading controls elite bias.

PANEL 13/14 — PYQ AND PRELIMS TRAPS

2018 GS-I: Chinese and Arab travellers → value + standpoint + corroboration
2023 Q46: literary attribution; local official key unavailable → do not invent
2024 Q55: site/state/type cells; official key B (rows 2 and 3)
TRAPS:
manuscript date ≠ composition | prashasti ≠ neutral chronicle
coin distribution ≠ empire | radiocarbon ≠ exact event year
aDNA ≠ language/caste/religion | absence ≠ non-existence
foreign ≠ objective | archaeology ≠ self-explaining

PANEL 14/14 — EXECUTABLE ANSWER METHOD

1. Decode directive and historical dimension.
2. Select source class fitted to that claim.
3. Write CLAIM → NAMED EVIDENCE → ANALYSIS → QUALIFICATION.
4. Add independent corroboration at matching time/place/scale.
5. State silence or residual uncertainty.
6. End with a graded verdict, not "all sources are important".

QUALIFIED CONCLUSION:
Ancient Indian history is strongest when independent archives constrain one another without erasing genre, context, survival bias or uncertainty.